The Dutch Session Tunebook

The most common tunes from the sessions in the Netherlands



2nd Edition, compiled by Tijn Berends, October 2016

Contents

Preface to the 2nd edition…….. 3

Preface to the 1st edition…….. 4

Concerning sessions…… 5

Part I…….. 7

Part II…….. 24

Part III…… 56

List of tunes…… 71

Preface to the 2nd edition

Hello again!

What you see before you is a much bigger and therefore much better version of my tunebook. There's a handful of extra jigs and reels, but most of the new tunes are hornpipes, polkas, slip jigs, waltzes and other types of tunes that were sadly absent in the first edition. Almost all of the tunes now have a small caption text that tells a bit about the history of the tune, describes possible variations or states random funny facts when I couldn't think of anything music-related to say.

The tunes are loosely ordered based on their difficulty (or at least my estimate of the same, which should not be taken too seriously), ranging from the absolute beginner's tunes in Part I to the half-advanced tunes in Part II.

Also new is the "Concerning Sessions" text. The session that Suzanne and I started in O'Leary's Pub in Utrecht has seen a strong increase in attendance, especially from beginning musicians. In order to give those people a bit of insight in the way a session works, I compiled this little descriptive text. Special thanks go to Annelies Berends, who was willing to discuss the subject matter at great length.

I hope this book will be of slightly more help than the first edition was. But to avoid people placing too much value on a bundle of paper, I quote from the previous edition's preface: by far the best way to learn music is to play. Listen to other musicians, adopt the things you like, keep experimenting, and above all: enjoy!

- Tijn Berends, October 2016

Preface to the 1st edition

Hello!

This lovely little book contains a selection of tunes that are very likely to be played at any session in the country. The melodies are the versions I know, which may not necessarily be the same ones you know yourself. This is due to the fact that tunes are played differently in different places and by different people. My own variations can depend on my mood, the instrument I am holding, the time of day and whether or not it is a full moon.

The same holds for the annotated chords, only more so. Accompanying tunes is a largely instinctive business, with no two musicians ever doing it exactly the same way. Variations are not only common, they are expected of you. The chords that are written with the tunes in this book are only a general indication of the structure of the tune.

Lastly, the selection of tunes that made it into the book is largely arbitrary. Some of them may be less well-known than I'd like, and there are certainly many common tunes that I did not include. Part of the reason for that is that this book is intended as an aid for beginning musicians, so that they can more easily fit in. Perhaps a bigger part of the reason is that it's my book, and I can do as I damn well please.

I hope this book will help you in some small way. Of course, by far the best way to learn music is to play. Listen to other musicians, adopt the things you like, keep experimenting, and above all: enjoy!

- Tijn Berends, March 2015

Concerning sessions

Although I've often heard it said that there are no rules to a session, I disagree. As with any social event, there are certain codes of conduct, breaking which will call down the displeasure of your fellow musicians upon you. These unwritten rules are not the same in every place, but there are a few which are pretty much universal. Although most of it seems obvious, it might not be so when you've not attended a session before, and so I will set them out here.

Music and instruments
Firstly, it's an Irish session where people play Irish traditional music. Maybe once an evening someone will do a pop song or a Breton mazurka as a little excursion, but that should be it. There are sessions that welcome other styles of folk music but since it's not standard they usually state so explicitly.

The same holds for instruments, although in a less strict way. Some non-traditional instruments can be present, but only if the musician really knows their business. I've heard some really good percussion on the cajón, or a really swinging reel on the clarinet, but those are rare exceptions.

The starter calls
The musician who starts a set gets to pick it. They choose which variation to play, at what speed, how often to repeat a tune, and which one to follow it up with. Although there are some sets of tunes that are almost always played together (like the Maid Behind the Bar and Cooley's), arranging new sets is allowed. If you play along with tune *X* that someone else started, don't just assume they will follow it up with tune *Y*. If they don't, you'll end up playing two different tunes, which doesn't make anybody happy.
This also means that if you start a tune, you must be able to lead it, and preferably have one or two others to follow it up with. When in doubt, ask the person next to you if they know it so you can start it together.

Different levels of skill
Be aware of your own level of musical skill and that of your fellow musicians. If a newly arrived musician starts a rather wobbly version of Egan's Polka, it is good form to join in even when they can't properly keep the rhythm or the tune. Every musician started out that way, including yourself!

In that same manner, when one of the more experienced players starts a tune that you just started learning, you might want to sit that one out if it's too fast for you. Trying to play along with a tune that goes beyond your skill will almost always detract from the overall sound and besides, if you don't play along you get to listen much more carefully and possible pick up new variations to try out for yourself later on.

Sheet music
Irish music is played by heart. Musicians at a session constantly interact with each other while playing: nods for changing key, smiles for cunning variations, looks of confusion for unknown tunes, etc. If your eye is locked onto a piece of paper with notes on it, you miss this key element of the music. Besides, sheet music is a poor representation of a tune in any case – ornamentation is never written down and the subtle rhythmic accents that make the difference between machine and musician couldn't be even if you tried.

Louder is not better
Be mindful of the volume of your instrument. Guitars and bodhráns create accompaniment and as such should add to the melody without drowning it. If there's more than one of such an instrument, players usually take turns – matching chords on two guitars is tricky business and if you don't get it right it will very quickly start sounding bad.

No rush
When a set is finished, take a moment to catch your breath, maybe ask for the name of the second tune, take a sip from your drink. You can wait a minute or two before starting a set of your own – especially if you already started the last set. Give other people a chance to pick a tune or a song too.

Stuck on repeat
Keep in mind what's already been played. Playing a tune twice in one evening is considered bad form (though obviously, if you arrived somewhat later and missed it the first time round, that's alright). Also, when someone just finished a mellow ballad, you might know one that's even slower, but it might be better to wait for another time, and follow it up with a nice set of jigs instead to lighten the atmosphere a bit.

Performance
A session is not a stage. Playing songs or tunes in band-specific way is a guaranteed way to annoy other musicians, since they will likely know the "vanilla" version and diverge from you halfway through. Things that detract from the musical quality for the sake of pleasing an audience, such as standing up while playing, playing with your banjo behind your neck, throwing your electric guitar into the crowd, stagediving, etc. are likewise viewed as unnecessary.

Lastly, and most importantly: enjoy!

Part I

[Polka] [D] Egan's Polka

Traditional



Egan's polka (or Peg Ryan's, or the Kerry, or the "FABA FABA", according the thesession.org) is the first tune kids in Ireland learn at music lessons. However, even though it's very easy to learn, it can be a very nice tune to play with a bit of swing.

[Jig] [D] The Kerfunken

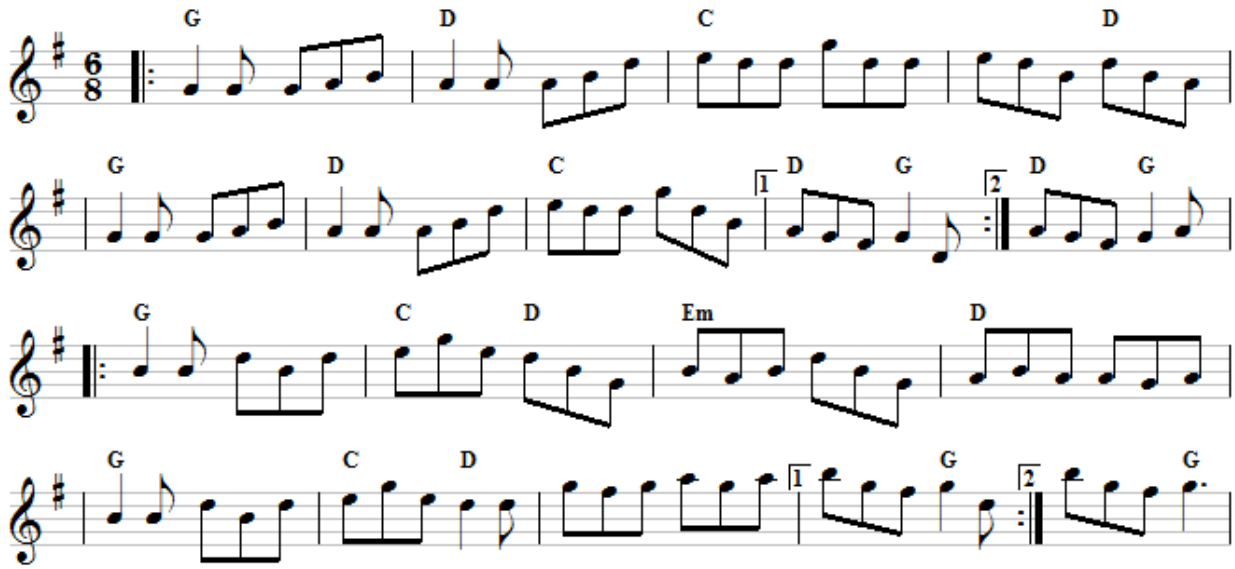
Hammy Hamilton



The Kerfunken was written fairly recently by Irish flute player and maker Hammy Hamilton. He named it after a French village he once visited, called Kerfuteun. The reason for the difference in spelling is not known, but it is suspected that alcohol may have been involved.

[Jig] [G] The Kesh

Traditional



The Kesh is one of the most common session tunes all over the world. Luka Bloom used it in his song "You Could't Have Come at a Better Time", with those words fit to the first two bars of the tune.
A nice variation for accompaniment is to play an open G chord through the whole first part, with a crescendo on the last few bars second time round. This gives a really nice drive when going into the second part.

[Polka] [A] Britches Full of Stitches

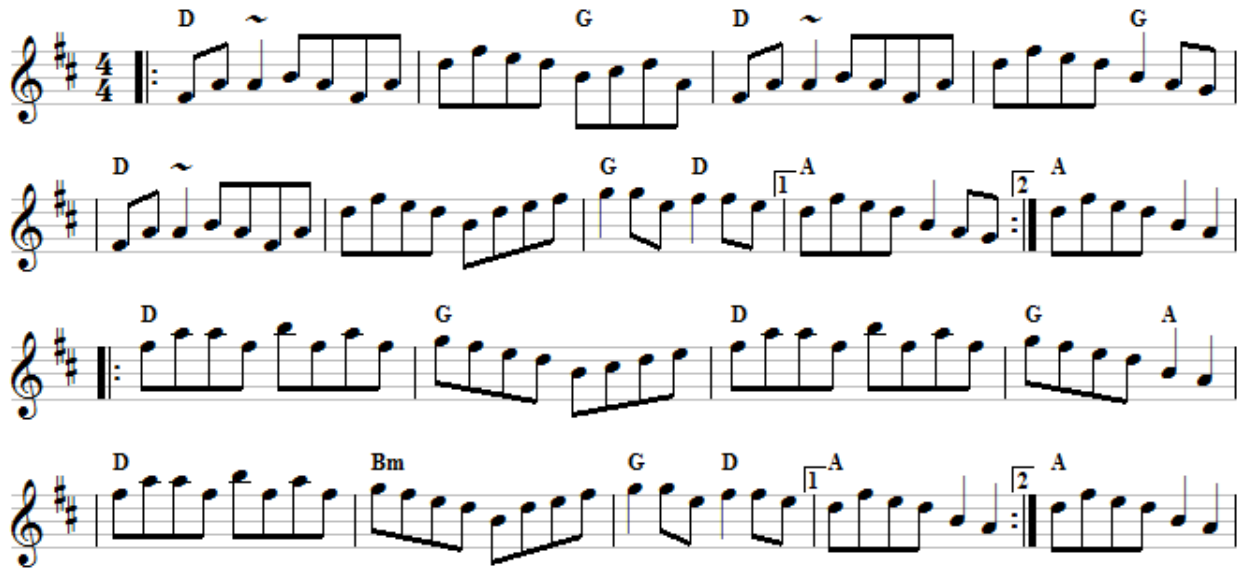
Traditional



Britches Full of Stitches too has words tied to the first two bars – the name of the tune, in this case.

[Reel] [D] The Silver Spear

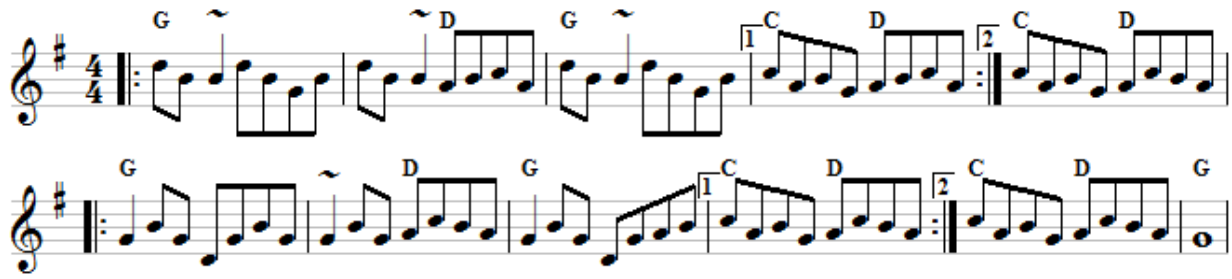
Traditional



The Silver Spear is one of the tunes without a proper end. If you don't make something up, it will keep on going all night – which is not necessarily a bad thing. A nice way to move on would be to follow it up with a reel in G that starts on the middle G, like the Sally Gardens.

[Reel] [G] The Blacksmith

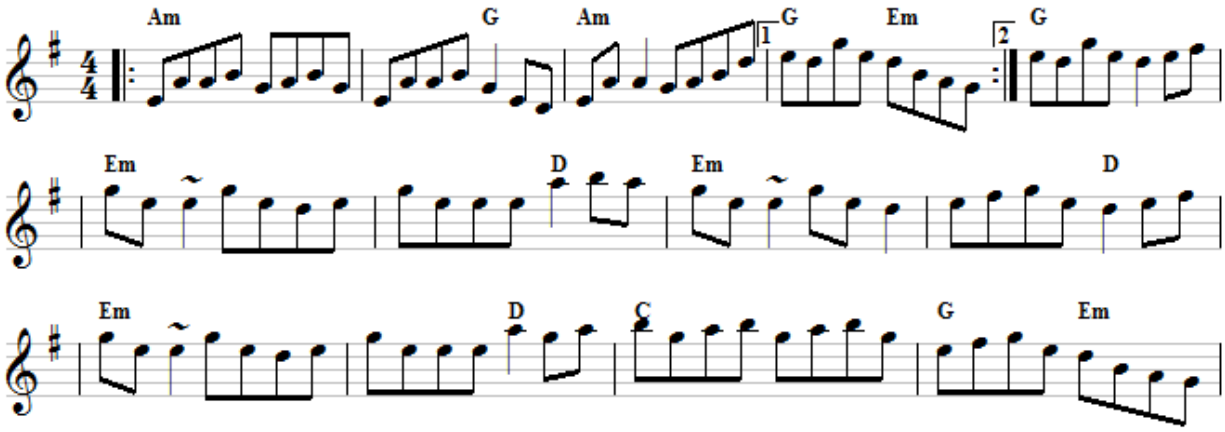
Traditional



The Blacksmith is what's called a single reel: instead of eight bars to a part there's only four. The discussion at thesession.org about the difference between "single reels" and "reels that are played singly" is long and boring, and will probably never end. Most people agree that a single reel is usually played slightly faster than a regular reel.

[Reel] [Am] The Sporting Paddy

Traditional



The Sporting Paddy too is a single reel. Although it has eight bars to the second part, they are not repeated, so there are still sixteen bars to the full tune instead of thirty-two.
The chords I usually play go to E minor in the second part, although many people just stick to the A minor chords of the first part. Both are fine, but I like the suspense my version creates, which gives a bit of extra drive to the tune when it resolves into the first part the next time round.

[Hornpipe] [G] Off to California

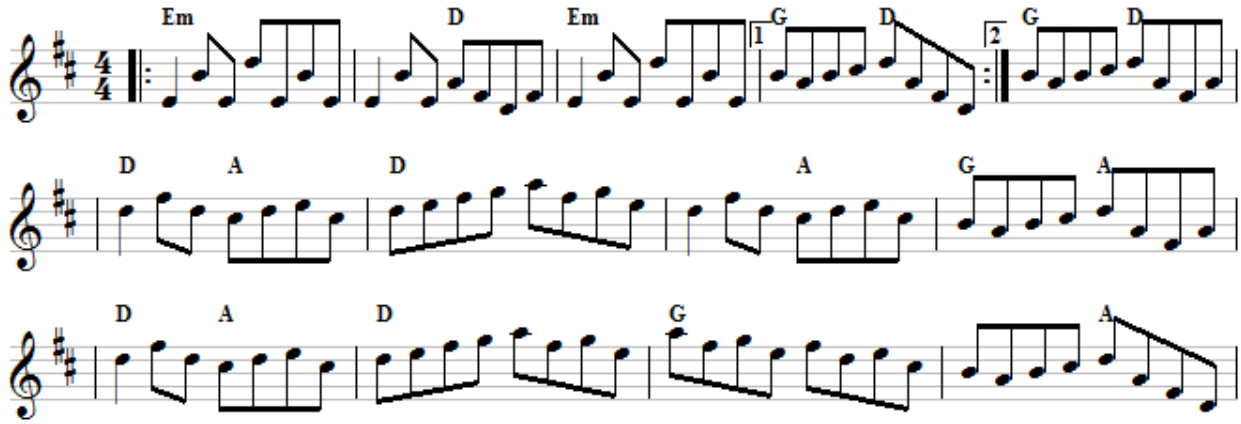
Traditional



Hornpipes are a nice example of how Irish musicians treat sheet music: what's written down is only a rough guideline to what's actually played, and you've got to know how to make the transition. Hornpipes are played with a "swing", where pairs of notes are played with the first one long and the second one short. Exactly how long and how short is difficult to pin down – it's close to 2:1, but not quite.

[Reel] [Em] Drowsy Maggie

Traditional



Drowsy Maggie has a “cuckoo note” structure in the first and third bars, where the tune is basically one note (the low E, called the “drone”) repeated with short “excursions” to other notes (the middle B and D) – like a cuckoo’s call. This is very common in Scottish highland pipes tunes and can be tricky to master on different instruments. Be careful to play the E’s in between the B and D and to keep them small. When done well, you’ll clearly hear the excursion notes, with the returning notes as a drone in the background.

[Jig] [D] The Humours of Glendart

Traditional



As with hornpipes, jigs have a rhythm that’s difficult to write down. The first note of every three is slightly longer than the other two (though not nearly as extreme as with hornpipes), and the second is very, very slightly shorter than the third. There’s no proper way to write this down, nor is there a need for one – just listen to other musicians to learn.

[Jig] [G] Out on the Ocean

Traditional



This tune offers some nice possibilities for variation in chords. In the first part, you can create some nice suspense by not playing the D chord at all (just stick to C). In the second part, there's a nice opportunity in the fifth bar to play a G/B on the third note to create a little scale in the bass notes there (G-B-C-D).

[Slip Jig] [Em] The Butterfly

Tommy Potts



Slip jigs often have relatively easy melodies. The 9/8th rhythm is what makes them challenging – it's tricky to learn at first, but very rewarding once you get the hang of it. For accompaniment instruments like bodhráns, guitars and bouzoukis, there's the added challenge of getting the up-down movement figured out, since you'll have to fit a down-down-up or an up-up-down in there somewhere, or play accents on the upbeats for every other bar.
Playing a 6/8th rhythm to a slip jig is a hanging offense.

[Reel] [D] The Merry Blacksmith

Traditional



There's some nice little opportunities for ornamentation in this tune. A lot of the bars start with a 1/4th note followed by the same 1/8th note. Replacing the 1/4th by a triplet gives a nice roll, which accents the start of the bar.

[Jig] [G] Saddle the Pony

Traditional



The second part of this tune starts with a 1/4th E followed by two 1/8th E's. There's plenty of variations possible to make this more interesting. Try playing just a 1/2nd E, or all 1/8th's, or a roll!

[Jig] [Am] The Lilting Banshee

Traditional



A very common variation to this tune is to play the first bar of the first and/or second line as |eAA eAA|, instead of |EAA EAA| (high E instead of low E, if you're not familiar with ABC notation). In fact, many people view this as the standard version, with low E as the variation.

[Hornpipe] [D] The Boys of Blue Hill

Traditional



According to thesession.org, the "Boys" in the name refer to buoys floating in the harbour of a little town in the USA. Since this tune already shows up in O'Neill's 1001 collection, there's probably no way to be sure.

The chords with this tune are my own preferred way of playing, with the first line ending with a G that's kept through half of the first bar of the second line. This means the change back to the tonic chord doesn't coincide with the start of the line anymore, making it slightly more challenging to keep the rhythm. But it surely sounds nice!

[Reel] [G] The Ballintore Fancy

Samuel Rowsome



Another single reel. The triplets are optional, but they do make the tune sound that much better.

[Reel] [D] The Mountain Road

Michael Gorman

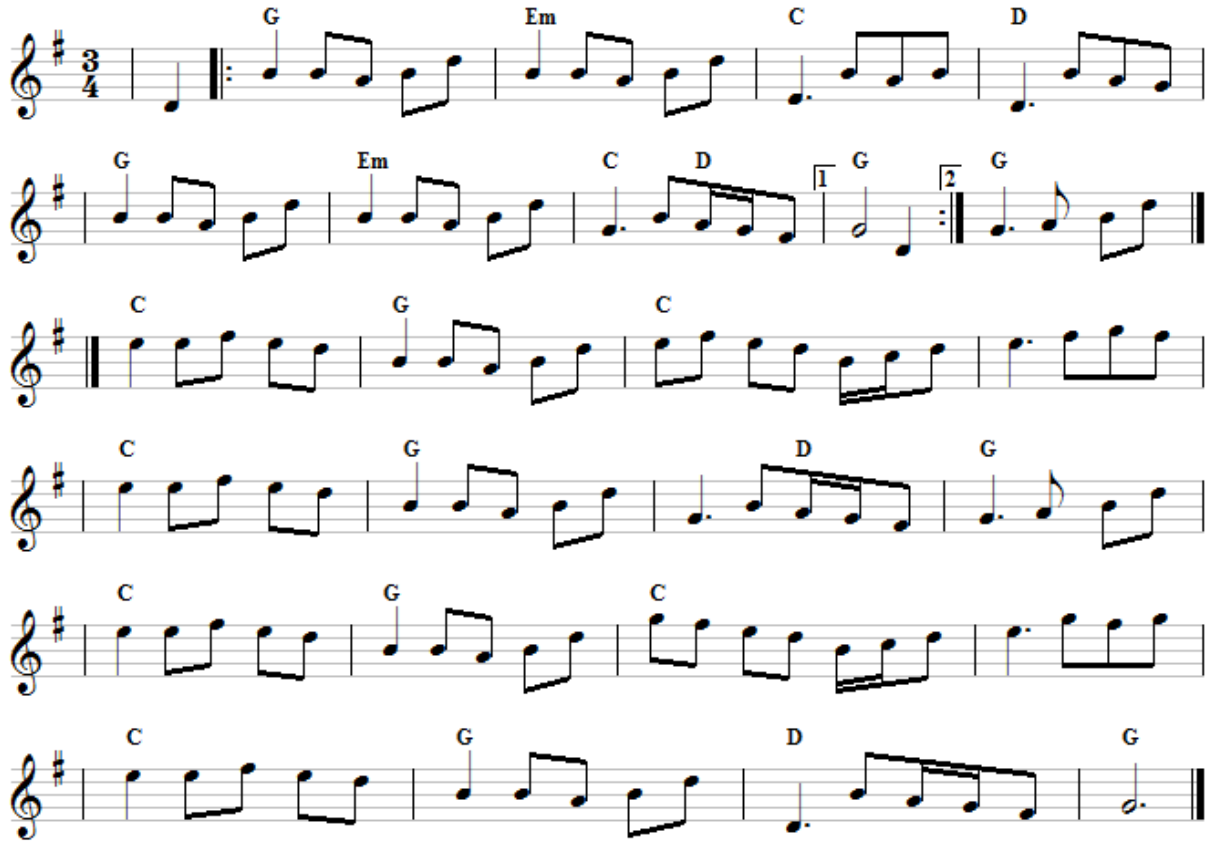


I looked up all the tunes in this tunebook on thesession.org, a treasure trove of tunes and stories, to find the original authors (if they are known). I was surprised to find that the Mountain Road was not even that old, and there was a link to a recording by the fiddler who wrote it. It turns out the original has six parts – SIX! Some day I'll learn them all, but for now I'll stick to the two-part version that everybody else plays.

Try placing slight accents on the F#'s in the first part – it gives it that nice swing that a reel should have.

[Waltz] [G] Inisheer

Thomas Walsh



This tune too was written surprisingly recently, and the author is still alive. Although this tune is played quite a lot at sessions, and not always equally well, it can be really hauntingly beautiful when played slowly. According to the author, it's supposed to be somewhere between an air and a waltz.

Inisheer (or Inis Oírr, the Irish spelling) is one of the Aran Islands – three tiny little islands lying in the middle of Galway Bay, on the western side of Ireland.

Try putting some vibrato on the long notes, and maybe a slide ("glissando", for the more classically educated) to make it come alive.

[Reel] [D] MacLeod’s Farewell (The Wedding Reel)

Donald Shaw



I was surprised to find that this tune too was written very recently by Donald Shaw. The name “The Wedding Reel” was attached to it by the band Lúnasa on one of their albums, where they also neglected to mention the original author. Whether or not this was an honest mistake is unclear, but since Lúnasa is far more renowned than mister Shaw, it’s now known more commonly as the Wedding Reel.

A common variation played around the Netherlands is to replace the three low A’s in the third bar of the second part by B♭’s.

[Jig] [Am] The Cliffs of Moher

Traditional



Although there are people who favour playing this one slow, and it certainly sounds nice enough that way, I always like to do this one rather fast, as it makes the rolls on the high A (first bar of the first part) and high E's in the second part a lot more impressive.

[Jig] [D] My Darling Asleep

Traditional



Alternatively called "My Darling's A Sheep", even though it's not a Scottish tune.

[Slip Jig] [Em] The Kid on the Mountain

Traditional



The Kid on the Mountain often baffles guitarists who've never heard it before. Technically it's a regular slip jig, but the 1/4th G in the first bar of the second and fifth parts makes it sound like a 6/8 jig for a few bars there. Although this can be quite confusing, this can be exploited to make the tune a bit more interesting by placing the chord change on that note, as I wrote it down above.

[Hornpipe] [G] The Sailor's Hornpipe

Traditional



Well known as the theme song of the old Popeye cartoons. I read that it was played in B♭ there, but since that's not really doable on many Irish instruments, most people at sessions play it in G.
This tune is nice for speeding up along the way, maybe repeating it four or five times.

[Slide] [Em] The Road to Lisdoonvarna

Traditional



Slides are not very common tunes, but they can be really fun to play. I've heard it said that a slide is to a jig what a polka is to a reel: faster. A slide is usually written down in 12/8 and has blocks of 3/8th length where more often than not it is made up of one 1/4th and a 1/8th note, rather than the three 1/8th's that are used in jigs.

Accompaniment can be tricky, since they're usually too fast for regular jig-time rhythms. Try accenting the first of every 6 notes, and "suggesting" the other five.

[Slide] [Em] O'Keefe's

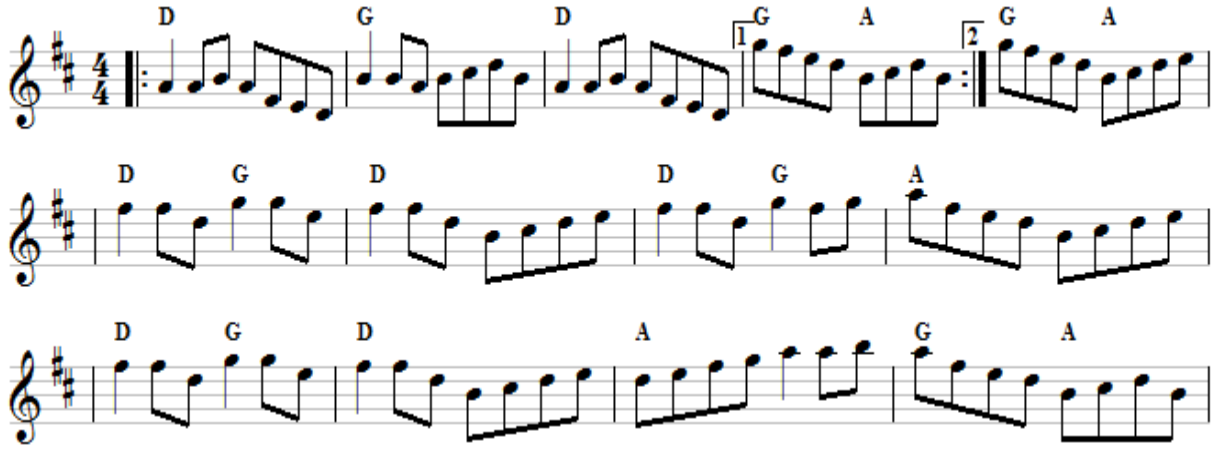
Dan O'Keefe



This one is often played in A minor rather than E minor. For violins it's all much the same, since it just means moving down one string. A minor offers possibilities for playing it in either the high or low octave for many instruments, which can be very nice. In my experience E minor is still the most common key for this tune.

[Reel] [D] The Wind that Shakes the Barley

Traditional



One of the most common reels in the world. This one benefits from being played quite fast, and offers nice possibilities for double-stopping on the violin (or similar double-notes on other instruments). Chords too can be endlessly experimented with, so the above should be viewed only as a very rough guideline.

[Reel] [Em] The Pride of Petravore

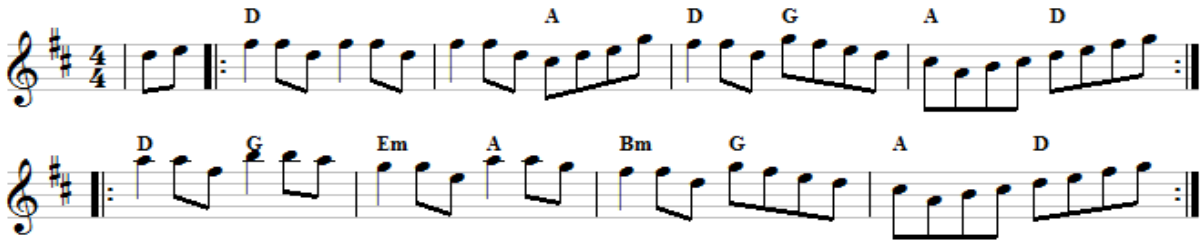
Traditional



This tune is originally a hornpipe rather than a reel, and a song rather than a tune: Eileen Óg, the prettiest girl in town, the pride of Petravore.

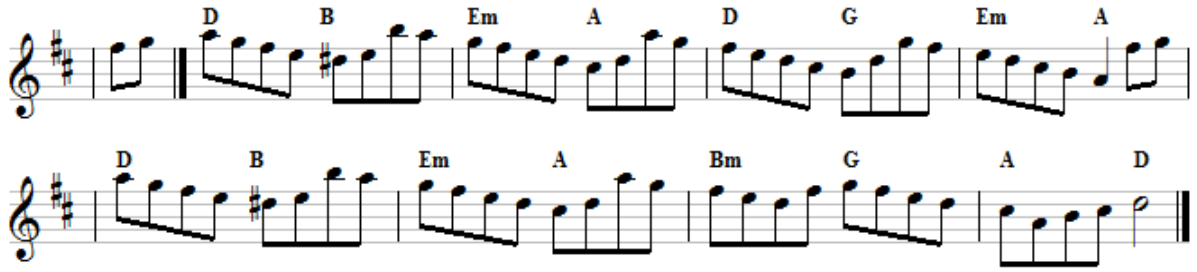
[Reel] [D] The Fairy Dance

Traditional



This is a Scottish tune that can be endless varied upon. Phil Cunningham and his late brother John, known from the band Silly Wizard, used to do this one on stage. They'd start it in A, go down to G, go up to D, go to D minor, back to D major, and do little variations even within the same key.

A nice variation on the second part that's often heard goes something like this (note the little D♯ in the first bar of both lines, which gives it a bit of a classical sound):



Part II

[Jig] [D] The Jig of Slurs

George McLennan

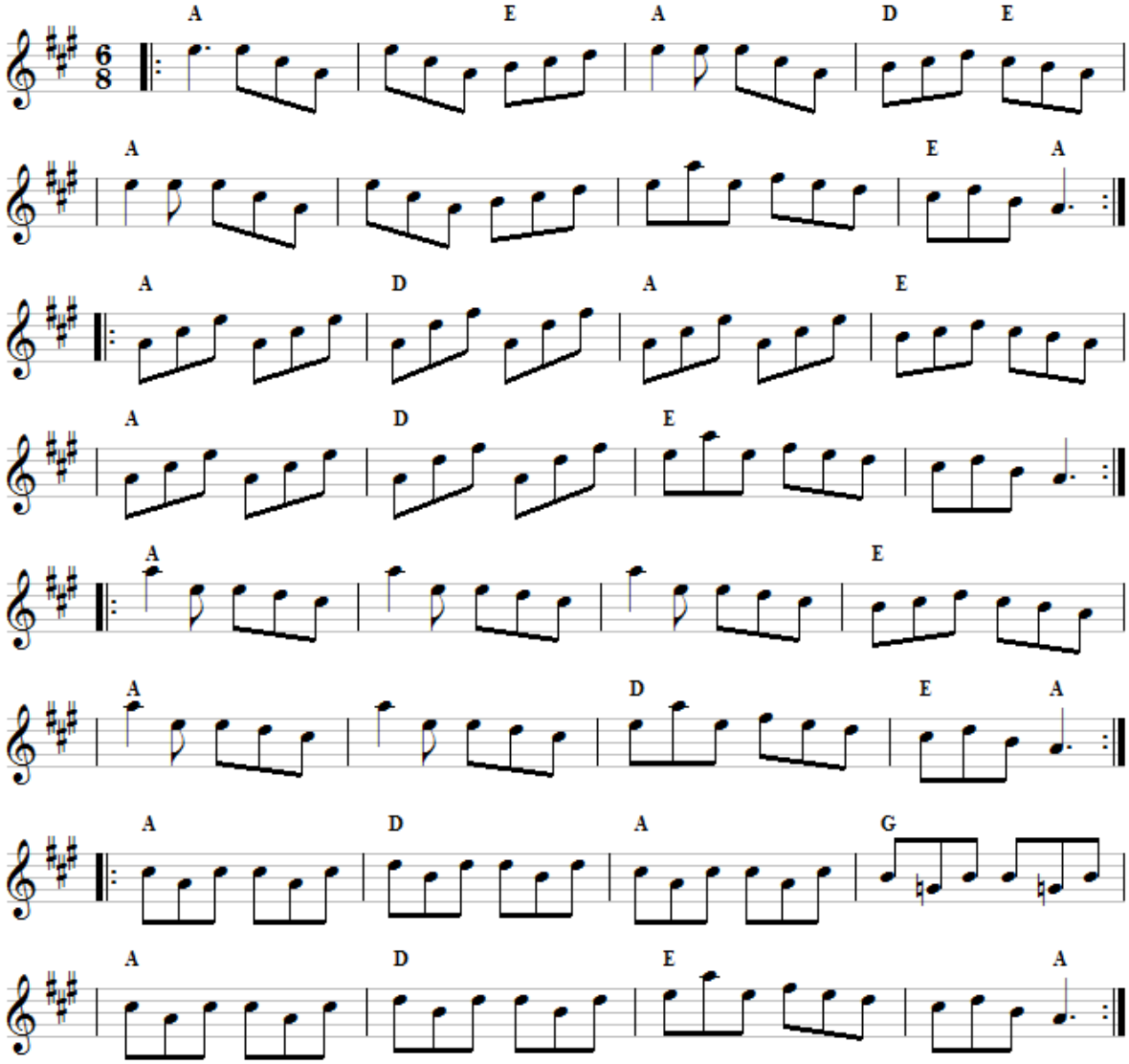


According to the discussion on thesession.org, this tune was written by Scottish piper George McLennan for his students to practice the “slur” – a type of ornamentation difficult to master on Highland pipes. It’s a very common tune in the Netherlands, especially at the session in O’Ceallaigh’s Irish Pub in Groningen.

Mind the key change from the second to the third part!

[Jig] [A] The Atholl Highlanders

Traditional



Also called “The Lord of Athol’s March”, this tune is indeed good as a marching tune when played a bit slower. However, in musical terms a march is a 2/4 tune, much like a polka but with more long notes and a very clear beat. This tune is most definitely a jig.

It is very common to make some sort of “jump” – either physically or by raising your instrument up into the air – on the high A notes in the third part. Some years ago I was at a session in Ireland where the people did this. I was happily surprised and (to my eternal embarrassment) assumed they’d also do the other common variation, which is to shout “HOY!” at the top of your lungs on the fourth note of the fourth bar of last part. I did, they did not.

[Reel] [D] The Maid Behind the Bar

Traditional



One of the most common reels in the world, but not the easiest to learn. Especially the second part can be tricky with the jumps between the high E and the high B.

[Reel] [Em] Cooley's

Traditional

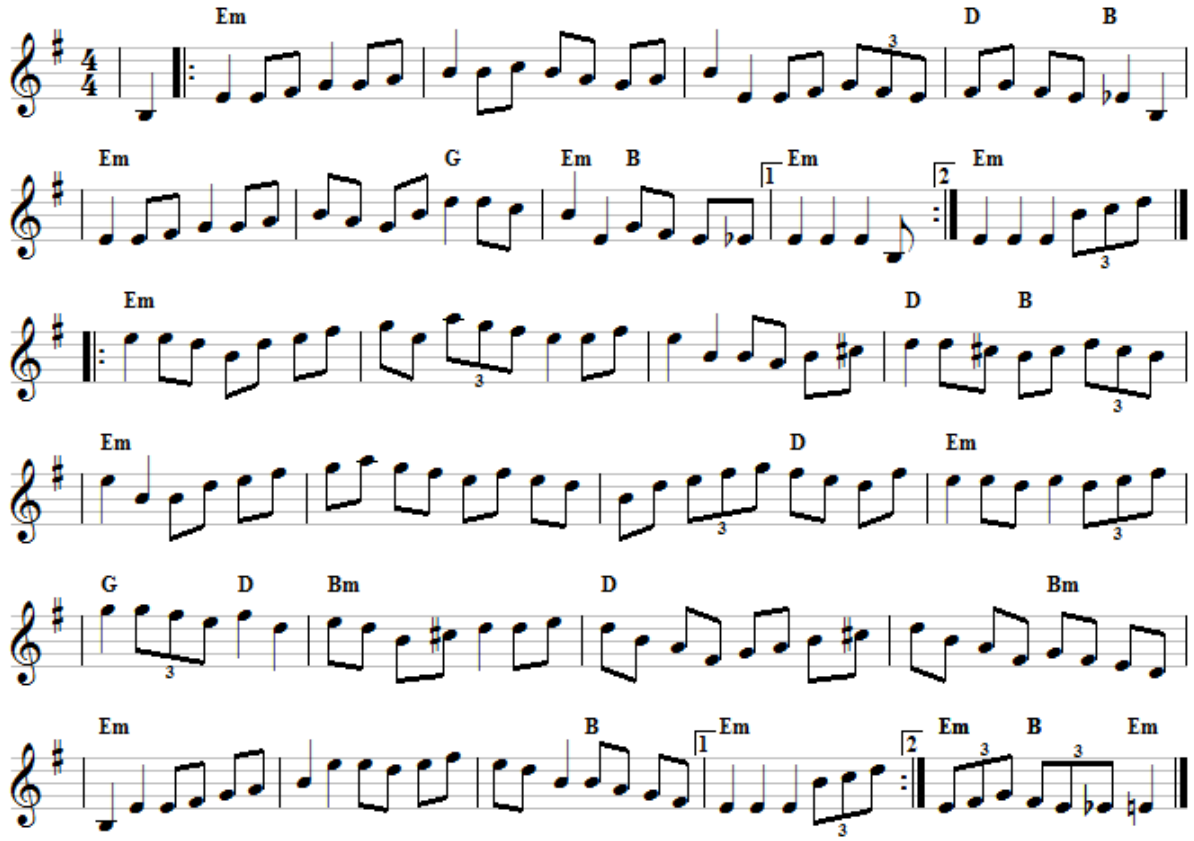


Cooley's is probably the most common reel in the world, but it too is not easy to play well. It only works when you get the reel rhythm, with a very slight accent on every third and seventh note in a bar, just right.

It is not entirely clear who wrote this tune, or what its original name was. Legendary squeezebox-player Joe Cooley (1924-1973) learned it at a young age and was so excited about it that he would play it for hours on end to practice, causing the tune to be named after him.

[Hornpipe] [Em] The King of the Fairies

Traditional



It’s very hard to pin down the key of this tune, especially since there are so many variations. Not many people play the E flats in the first part and in the last bar of the second part. Leaving those out and playing it slightly faster pushes the sound towards E dorian (two sharps), where the C naturals are the exception. I myself favour the slower E minor version (one sharp), with the C sharps as exceptions. Combined with the E flats and the B major chords in the accompaniment, this gives it a lovely, sort of mysterious sound.

[Polka] [G] Maggie in the Woods

Traditional



There's lots of opportunities for variation in chords with this tune. Try substituting some of the G major chords in the second part by E minor, or leaving out the D major at the end of the first line.

[Polka] [D] The Maids of Ardagh

Traditional



Mind the key change! I personally hold that this tune can be played with very little ornamentation, in a very staccato way – but that's just me.

[Jig] [Dmix] The Blarney Pilgrim

Traditional



This tune is an eternal spring of confusion amongst guitarists, who never seem able to figure out what it is in. In my version, the first part is D mixolydian, the second is in G major and the third part is once again in D mixolydian. Both keys have the same notes, so arguing over the correct key is rather pointless, but it changes what chords to use. The above version is what I settled on after a long time of experimenting. I've heard it played with the first part in G, which always hurts my ears. I've also heard the third part played in G, which hurts my soul. This is my book, and so here my word is law: Dmix it is!

[Jig] [Am] Condon's Frolics

Traditional



[Reel] [G] The Sally Gardens

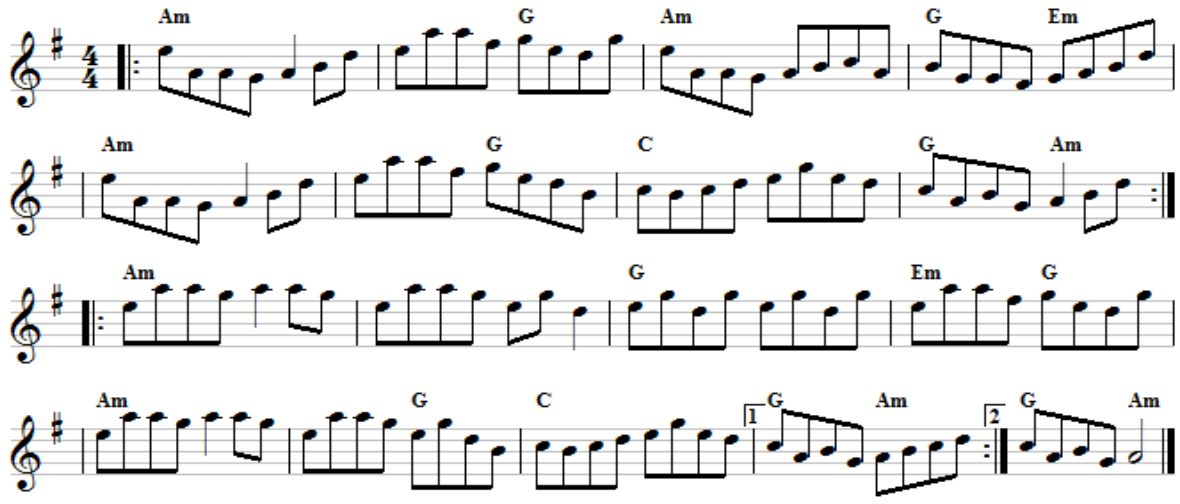
Traditional



Although many people regard this tune as boring, easy and played too often, I disagree. It's a very nice tune when you play it right. The first part has a phrase with a droning B and cuckoo notes to the high D and E, and the second part has this droning high G with syncopated cuckoo notes to the high D. Accent these high D notes with the accompaniment and the result can be really lovely.

[Reel] [Am] The Congress Reel

Traditional



This tune is a personal favourite of mine, since it's one of the first reels I learned to play properly on the harmonica. Try substituting the A minor in the last line by an F major for variation, or different rhythms for the first line (4-4, 3-3-2, 2-3-3 or even 3-3-3-3-2-2).

[Jig] [D] The Connaughtman’s Rambles

Traditional



A lovely, gentle jig. Especially the first part has this really nice mellow sound, which profits from only the smallest accompaniment. A good tune for filling up the middle of a set, or for kicking off after someone has sung a sensitive ballad.

[Jig] [D] Calliope House

Dave Richardson



This jig was originally written in the key of E. Nobody knows why but most people agree it sounds just as good in D and is much easier to play that way. Even though it was written very recently there are many different variations to be found, especially of the second part.

[Slip jig] [G] Na Ceannabhain Bhana

Traditional



A very easy slip jig to learn and still very nice to play. Dervish did a sung version of this on one of their earlier albums, where for some reason they saw fit to put 12 notes in every second bar.

[Reel] [Am] Revenge of the Harmonica

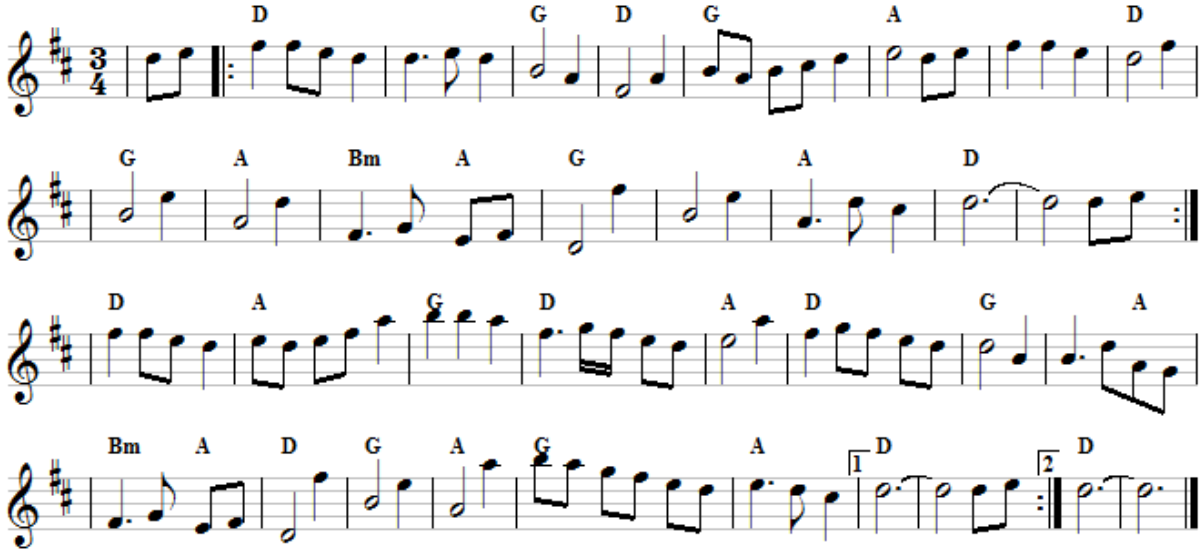
Tijn Berends



Here's one of the first tune I wrote myself. Although this technically isn't a common session tune yet, I certainly plan to make it become one – which is why it's in this book! The second line of the third part works well with the tension-building D – Em – F – G chord progression.

[Waltz] [D] Si Beag Si Mor

Turlough O'Carolan



Probably the most famous O'Carolan tune. Turlough O'Carolan (1670-1738) was a blind harper and one of the last proper bards – a traveling musician who made his living by playing for the gentry and writing songs or tunes in their honour. 214 different surviving tunes have been attributed to him. Some people claim that the first part of this waltz was an already existing tune called "The Cuckoo's Call", which Carolan expanded with a second part. Playing the first part slowly certainly shows how it would have come by that name.

[Slip Jig] [Em] A Fig for a Kiss

Traditional



To me this tune sounds best when played slow. I've even heard it played as music for a balfolk "mazurka" – a dance similar to a waltz, but slower and more sensual.

[Jig] [D] The Lark in the Morning

Traditional



This tune is best placed at the end of a set of jigs that is already too long. Just when you've finished five or six tunes at breakneck speed, when the flutist is gasping for air, the violinist is getting a tennis arm and the guitarist's fingers are dripping blood onto the floor – that's the moment to start this tune. Nobody wants to admit how exhausted they are and so they'll play it three or even four times round. Musicians can be stubborn people.

[Reel] [G] The Teetotaller

Traditional



There's a lot of reels with this general sound – the first part in G and the second part too but with the tonal centre temporarily shifting to E minor. The second bar of the first part is almost identical to the same bar in the Sally Gardens – the same B drone with D and E cuckoo notes. Then again, it's a very common phrase.

[Reel] [Am] The Star of Munster

Traditional



Although this is a very common tune, it's not the easiest to play. Especially the second part, with its E drone with G and A cuckoo notes, can be tricky to play on some instruments. Combined with the fact that this tune is generally played very fast, many people often choose to just listen and sip their drinks instead.

[Slide] [D] Johnny Mickey's

Traditional



Hurray for slides! These two were on a compilation album I bought at a festival some years ago. They are really fun tunes and relatively easy to play. The second one has an interesting key change that occurs gradually in the second line of the first part, switching from D to A. You could almost say the whole thing is in A with the first line simply centring on the D. That's just details, but the chords are quite clear.

[Slide] [D] Padraig O'Keefe's

Traditional



[Polka] [D] Dennis Murphy’s

Traditional



This is a very common set of polka’s to play in the north of the Netherlands. The second one is one of the most common tunes in the world, made especially famous by its rendition by Gaelic Storm in the movie “Titanic”. The trick of strumming two really loud D chords on the two D’s in the first bar and then remaining silent for the rest of the first and second bars, and the same for the third and fourth and the fifth and sixth is pretty much universal – mostly because it just works so well!

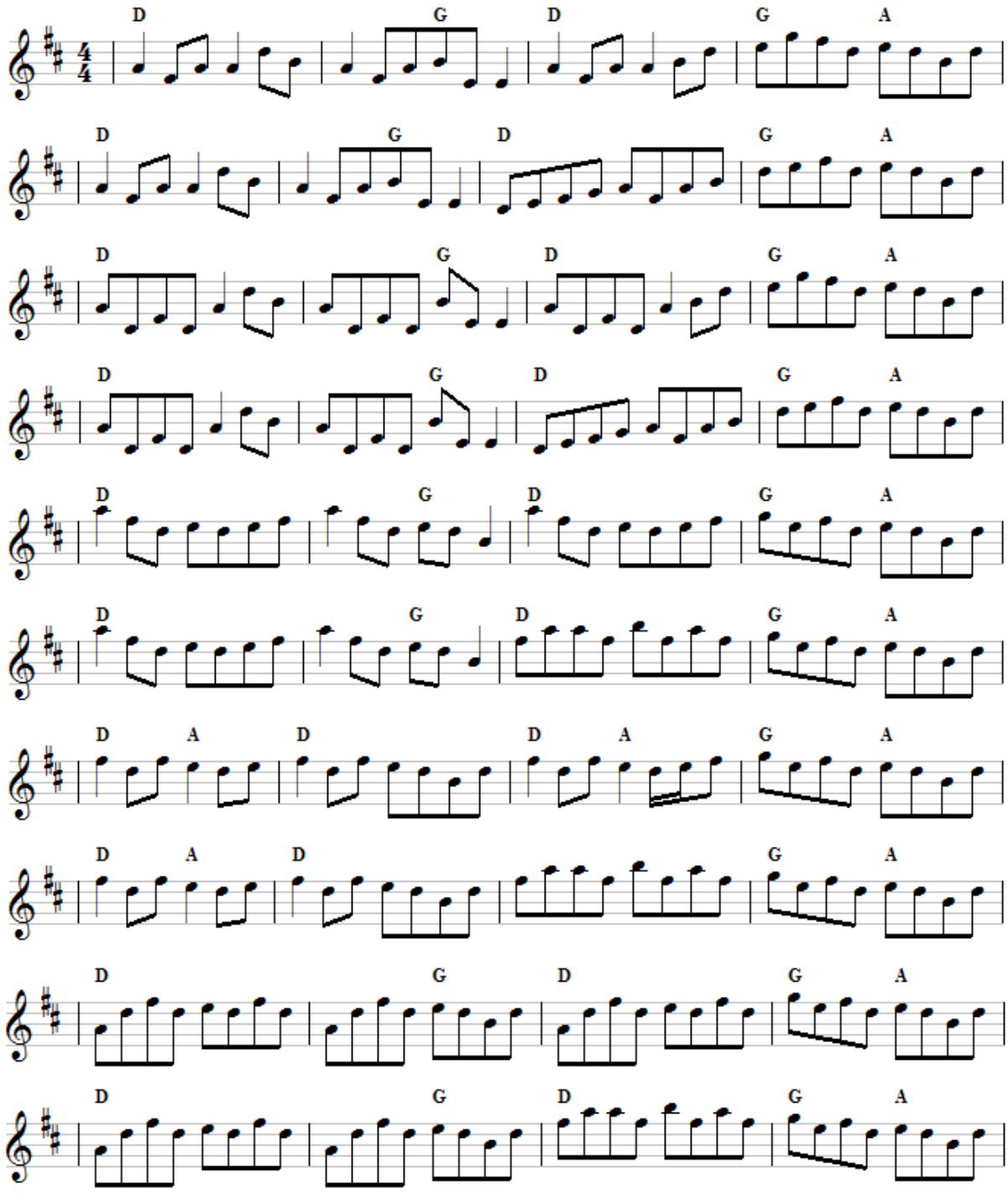
[Polka] [D] John Ryan’s

Traditional



[Reel] [D] The Bucks of Oranmore

Traditional



Known colloquially as simply “The Bucks”, this tune is usually played at the end of a session, since it’s so bloody long. I mean, a single reel with five parts, honestly? Still, it’s a very nice tune to play – especially, in my opinion, when played not too fast.

[Jig] [D] Tripping Upstairs

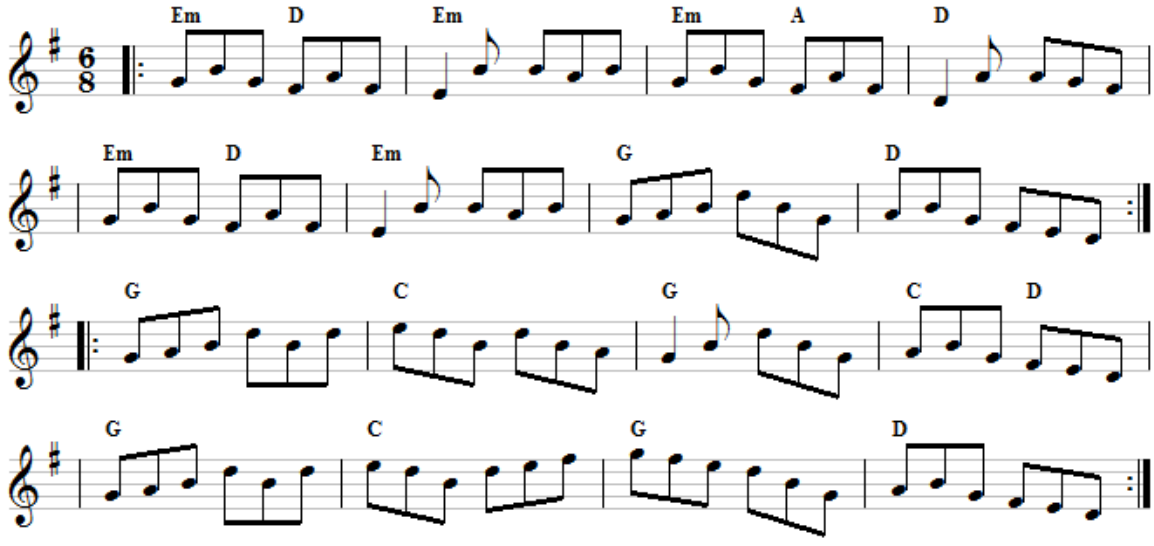
Traditional



If your instrument allows this, try playing some really loud bass notes to support the D – G – D chords in the first two bars. If not, try playing just | F3 G3 | A3 fed | as a variation.

[Jig] [Em] The Leitrim Fancy

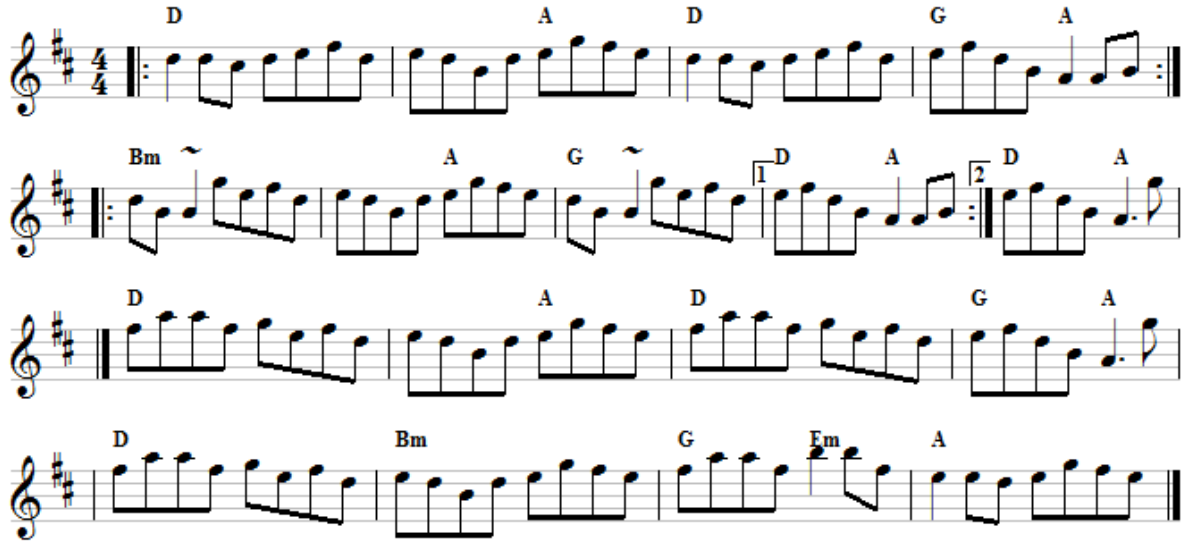
Traditional



In the sessions in Groningen and Deventer, this jig is usually played after Tripping Upstairs and then followed by Jim Ward's. You could also follow it with something like the Blarney Pilgrim, since it already works towards the low D at the end.

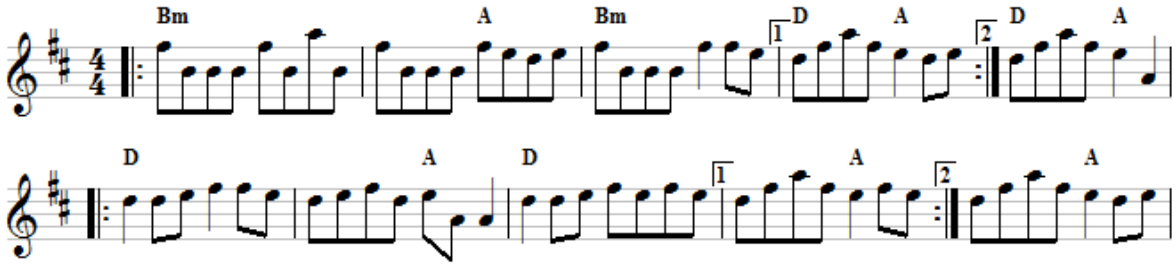
[Reel] [D] Rip the Calico

Traditional



[Reel] [Bm] The Glass of Beer

John McFadden



Both these tunes are best played fast. Really fast.

[Hornpipe] [Em] The Rights of Man

Traditional



Dé Dannan did a wonderful rendition of this hornpipe paired with the Pride of Petravore on one of their albums. I've heard it played slowly and that can also sound nice, but I prefer it fast, with the rolling triplets in the first and fifth bar. Not easy, but very rewarding.

[Reel] [Em] The Drunken Landlady

Traditional



Be sure to ornament the long low E's in the first part – rolls, triplets, anything really. The same goes for the long high E's in the second part.

[Jig] [Em] The Swallowtail

Traditional



[Jig] [Am] The Dusty Windowsills

John Harling



Fiddler John Harling was inspired to write this tune while fetching something from the attic. Fearing he would lose the melody if he didn't write it down somewhere, he wrote it with his finger in the dust on the window.

[Jig] [Dmix] The Hag at the Churn

Traditional



The Bothy Band recorded a great version of this jig with some wailing high notes on the pipes to go with the first part. They also managed to play it eight or nine times through without it getting boring. This is not recommended for sessions.

[Jig] [G] Jim Ward's

Traditional



A very common jig with an unusual chord progression in the second part. You could also play an Am instead of the C, but I've personally never liked the sound of that. Try adding some high D drones in that C chord for extra suspense.

[Reel] [G] The Banshee

James MacMahon



A banshee is a creature from Celtic folklore. Its call, a terrible screeching wail, supposedly heralds the death of the person who hears it. According to the discussion on thesession.org, telling scary stories about the banshee is a traditional Irish remedy against constipation in infants.

[Polka] [G] Sweeney's Polka

Traditional



Like most polka's, this tune benefits from being played with a lot of staccato on the 1/8th notes. The chords written down here for the second part show a possible syncopated rhythm, where the chord change doesn't coincide with a bar.

[Reel] [G] Miss McLeod’s

Traditional



[Reel] [Am] The Gravelwalks

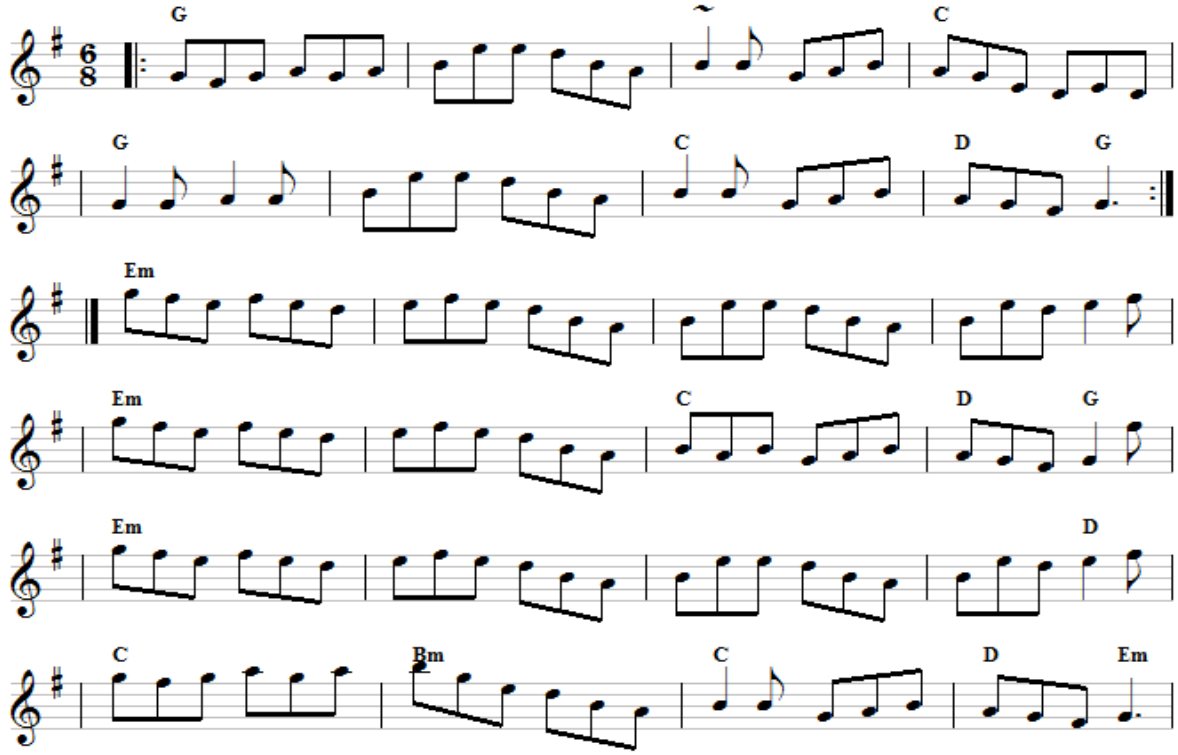
Traditional



The Gravelwalks is a bit of an oddity when it comes to repetitions. The first three parts are a single reel, with 8 bars to a part after repetition. The fourth part, with its C chord, has 8 bars that are played twice. Best played fast and loud, usually at the end of a set.

[Jig] [G] Donnybrook Fair

Traditional



One day I'll learn the lyrics to this thing. All eight verses!

[Jig] [D] Jig Runrig

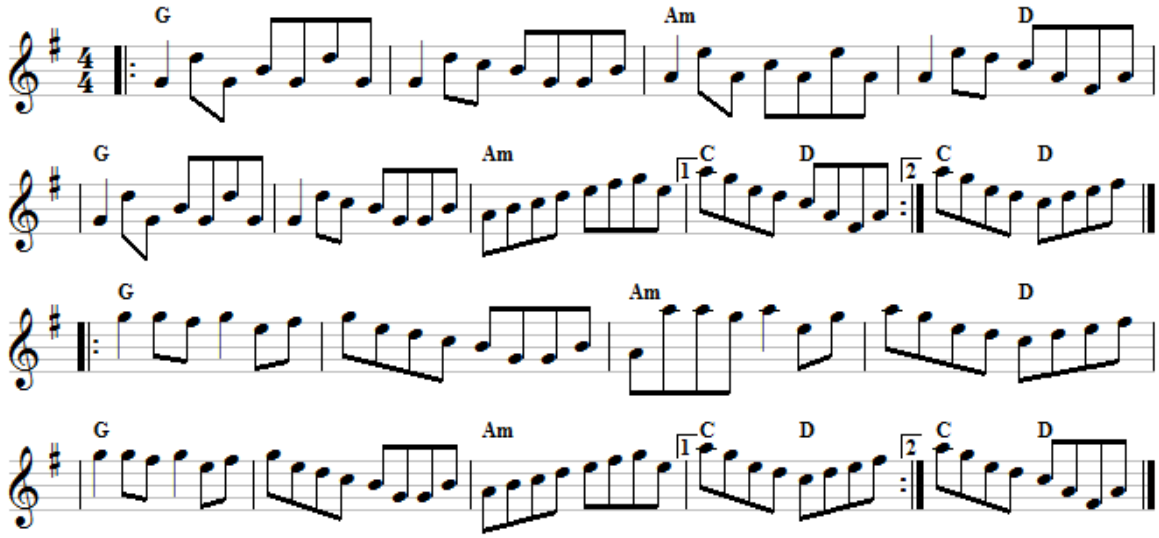
Fergie MacDonald



Scottish accordionist Fergie MacDoland wrote this tune quite recently and it's already one of the most popular session tunes in Scotland. It can be played slow and gently or a bit faster and more lively, but be careful to keep the second part "clean" – the cuckoo notes going down beneath the high A drone can be tricky to get right.

[Reel] [G] The New Copperplate

Traditional



This reel always brings to my mind the sound of a very traditional Irish ceili band, with a piano and snare-drum creating the corny oom-pah sound that makes your toes curl upwards. Still, it's fun enough to play and easy to learn.

[Reel] [Am] The Old Copperplate

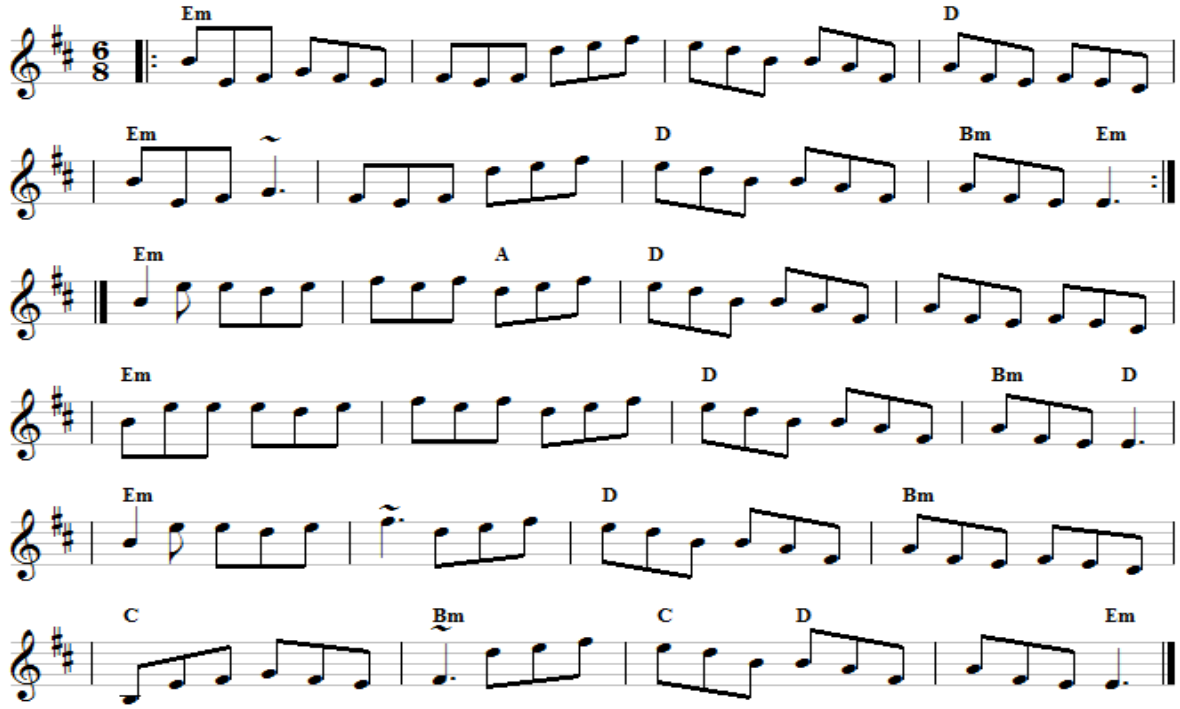
Traditional



I always get the Old and New copperplates mixed up – in my head, they're just the G one and the Am one. The Am one has the most generic chord progression you'll ever hear for an Am reel. The D chord "eases" the transition from Am to G and the Em chord does the same when going back. I added a little F chord in the last line as a substitution for the Am, just to keep the boredom to an acceptable level.

[Jig] [Em] The Sheep on the Boat

Traditional



[Hornpipe] [D] The Fisher's

Traditional



This tune was made famous by the second "Pirates of the Caribbean" movie. For reasons unknown the orchestrated version there is played in F and in reel-time, without the hornpipe swing. Try adding some more triplets here and there – the ones written down here are only an example.

[Jig] [Dmix] I Buried My Wife (And Danced on her Grave)

Traditional



A friend of mine once played a set with “My Darling Asleep”, “Pull the Knife and Stick it Again” and lastly this jig. When the last tune started, the musicians who know the names of their tunes all smiled. Musicians have a very peculiar sense of humour.

[Jig] [G] The Irish Washerwoman

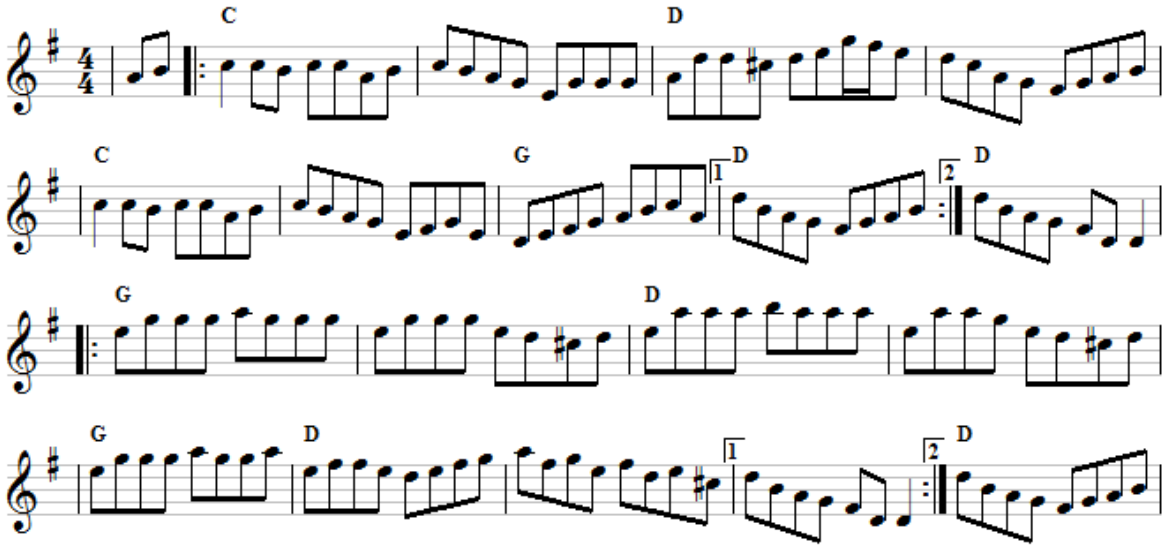
Traditional



One of the few Irish tunes that many non-Irish musicians know. John Sheahan, former fiddler of The Dubliners, once did a live performance of this tune with André Rieu and his entire orchestra. They kept going faster and faster and nowadays many bands play it that way on stage.

[Reel] [Dmix] The Rakish Paddy

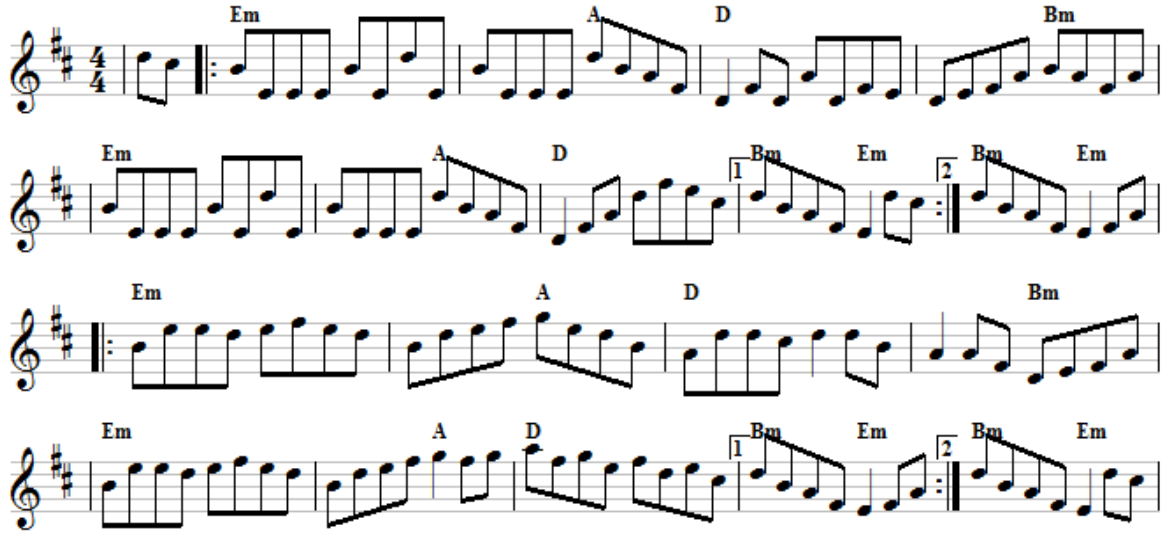
Traditional



I've read that the first bar should properly read | c4 c2AB |, and that cutting these long C notes into smaller bits is wrong. It's a matter of taste, I guess – I've never actually heard it played that way. Guitarists often stumble over the chords of this tune. It's in Dmix but since the parts start either with C or G this can be tricky to hear.

[Reel] [Em] The Pigeon on the Gate

Traditional



Want to play cuckoo notes from a low E drone but getting tired of playing Drowsy Maggie? Try the Pigeon on the Gate for a change!

[Waltz] [G] The South Wind

Traditional



Try to find a balance between ornamentation and simplicity for this tune. A little vibrato on the long notes, a slur here and there and maybe a grace note to accent certain phrases will certainly help with the expression, but it’s easy to get carried away and overdo it.

[Reel] [D] The Trip to Durrow

Traditional



One of my favourite tunes. The second part is unusual because of its four lines. Some people claim that these are in fact two parts and that it's played AABCBC, evidenced by the fact that there are also people who play it AABBCC. I've never heard it played that way, so I'll stick with this.

[Reel] [Em] The Cup of Tea

Traditional



This tune really springs out – the phrases are all very common, but the structure of one part in Em and two parts in D is not often seen. The transition from the first to the second part can be difficult to make for guitarists, since the chord remains the same but its function within the key changes. I usually play the D at the end of the first part light and high and add more bass when starting the second part to emphasize this.

[Reel] [D] The Pinch of Snuff

Traditional



This tune's a proper monster. In a way, it's a really simple two-part single reel that's repeated in different keys: low D, G, A and high D. Then there's one repeated part to make the transition from high D to low D more fun, and you start over.

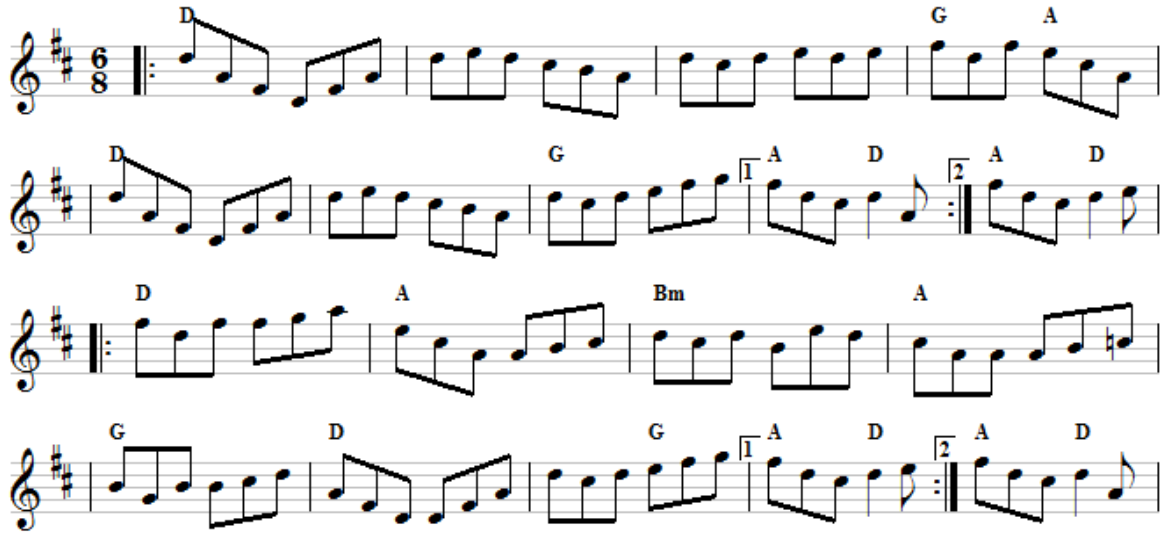
This tune is usually played on its own because it's so long. A little gimmick from the session in Groningen is to end on the C note in the third bar of the last part – there's always someone who forgets and plays on for a few notes. The other musicians will then laugh at him or her.

It's a musician thing.

Part III

[Jig] [D] Father O'Flynn

Traditional



Lyrics from a 1906 recording by Andrew Black:

Of priests we can offer a charmin' variety,
Far renown'd for learnin' and piety;
Still, I'd advance ye widout impropriety,
Father O'Flynn as the flow'r of them all.

Chorus:
Here's a health to you, Father O'Flynn,
Slainte and slainte and slainte agin;
Pow'rfulest preacher, and tenderest teacher,
And kindliest creature in ould Donegal.

Don't talk of your Provost and Fellows of Trinity,
Famous forever at Greek and Latinity,
Dad and the divils and all at Divinity
Father O'Flynn 'd make hares of them all!

Come, I venture to give ye my word,
Never the likes of his logic was heard,
Down from mythology into thayology,
Truth! and conchology if he'd the call.

Och Father O'Flynn, you've a wonderful way wid you,
All ould sinners are wishful to pray wid you,
All the young childer are wild for to play wid you,
You've such a way wid you, Father avick.

Still for all you've so gentle a soul,
Gad, you've your flock in the grandest control,
Checking the crazy ones, coaxin' onaisy ones,
Lifting the lazy ones on wid the stick.

And tho quite avoidin' all foolish frivolity;
Still at all seasons of innocent jollity,
Where was the playboy could claim an equality,
At comicality, Father, wid you?

Once the Bishop looked grave at your jest,
Till this remark set him off wid the rest:
"Is it lave gaiety all to the laity?
Cannot the clergy be Irishmen, too?"

[Jig] [Em] Morrison’s

Traditional



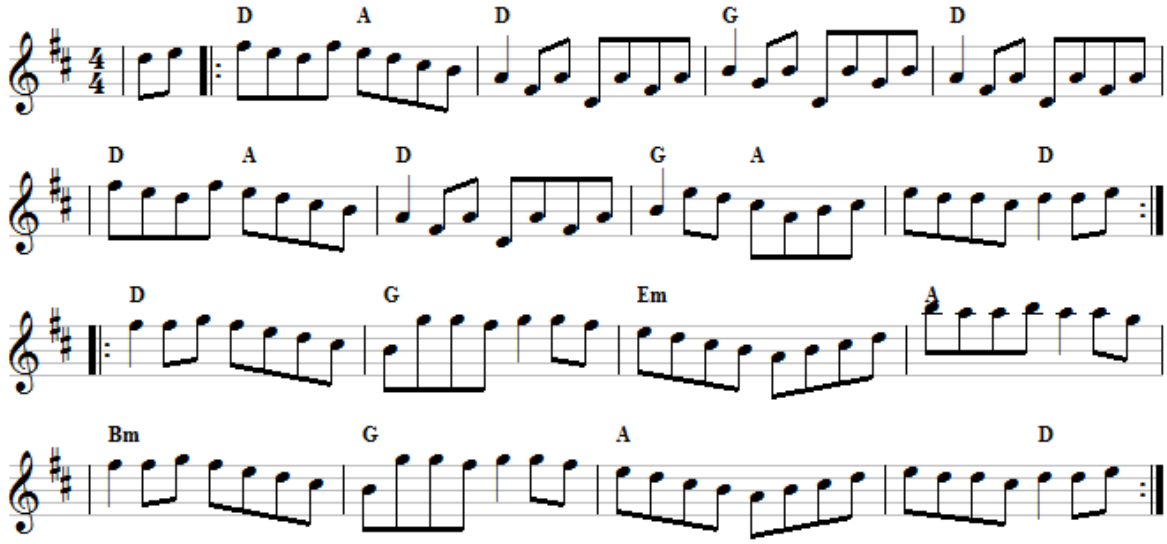
The first two bars have a low E drone with B cuckoo notes. Be careful to play the E in between the B’s – the tunes stands or falls with these notes.

The G chord at the start of the last line is often replaced by a C. This adds some extra suspense and is therefore more properly a variation than a standard way of playing it.

A common way to end this tune is to append two extra bars at the end: | E2 E2 E2 | E6 |

[Reel] [D] St. Anne's

Traditional



Lyrics of "The Ballad of St. Anne's Reel",
a song that's tied to the tune:

He was standing in some tiny town,
on fair Prince Edward Island.
Waiting for a ship to come and find him.
A one-horse place, a friendly face,
some coffee and a tiny trace of fiddling
in the distance far behind him.

A dime across the counter then,
a shy hello, a brand new friend,
a walk along the street in the wintry weather.
A yellow light, an open door,
a welcome friend, there's room for more.
And soon they're standing there inside, together.

He said, I've heard this tune before somewhere,
but I can't remember when.
Was it on some other friendly shore,
did I hear it on the wind?
Was it written on the sky above,
did I hear it from someone I loved?
But I never heard it sound so sweet since then.

Now his feet begin to tap,
a little boy says, I'll take your hat.
He's caught up in the magic of her smile.
And leap the heart inside him went,
and off across the floor he sent,
his clumsy body graceful as a child.

He said, there's magic in the fiddler's arms,
there's magic in this town.
There's magic in the dancer's feet,
and the way they put them down.
There's people smiling everywhere,
there boots and ribbons, locks of hair.
And laughter, old blue suits and Easter gowns.

Now the sailor's gone, the room is bare,
the old piano's sitting there.
Someone's hat left hanging on the rack.
An empty chair on the wooden floor,
that feels the touch of shoes no more,
waiting for the dancers to come back.

And the fiddle's in the closet
of some daughter of the town.
The strings are broken, the bow is gone
and the case is buttoned down.
But sometimes on December nights,
when the air is cold and the wind is right,
there's a melody comes passing through this town.

[Waltz] [Bm] Wild Asparagus

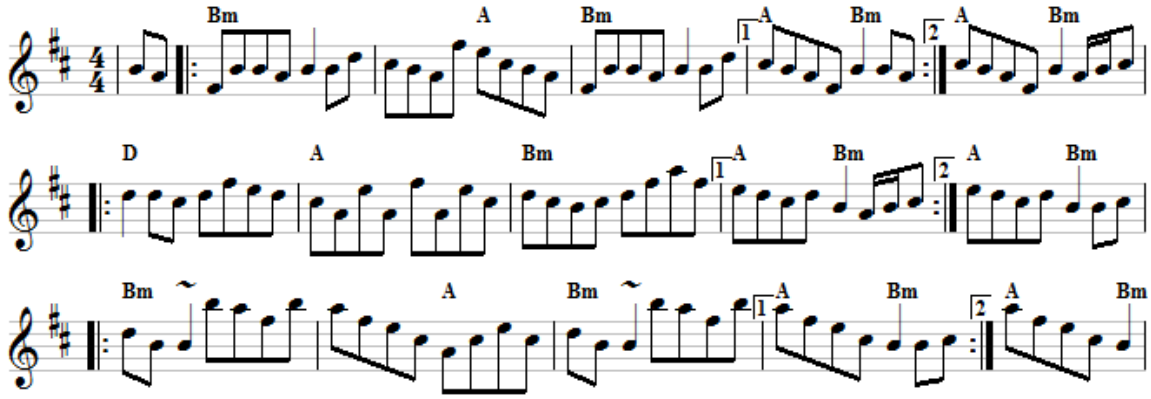
Pete Jung



According to the author: “I wrote it for a particular woman who has an enchanting but elusive quality—that was what I was trying to convey. All I got out of this deal was the tune.”

[Reel] [Bm] The Musical Priest

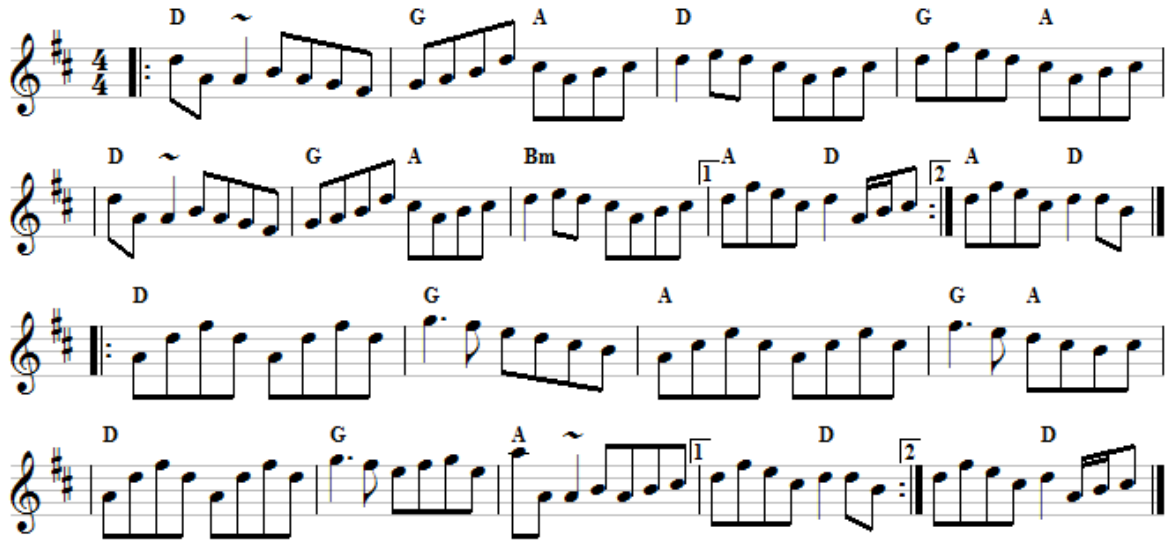
Traditional



The first two parts of this reel are easy enough; it’s the third part people usually trip over. Phil Cunningham and his late brother John, formerly of Silly Wizard, used to play a set of reels at breakneck speed that ended with this tune. They played a five-part version, but we mere mortals will have to contend ourselves with three parts.

[Reel] [D] Paddy’s Trip to Scotland

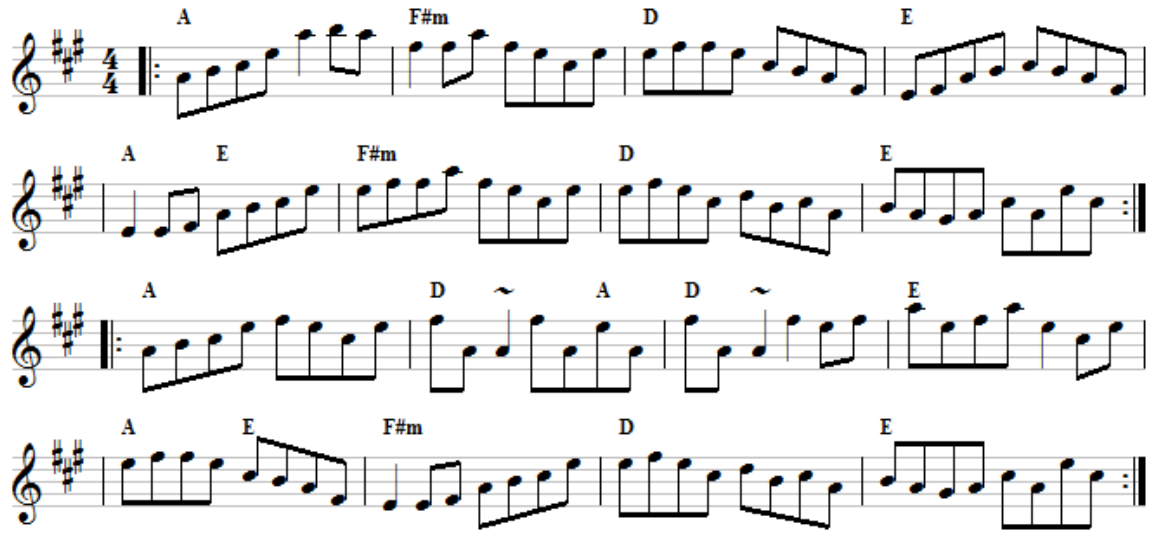
Traditional



The D broken chord in the second part of this tune has a nice variation:
| AdfA dfAd | fggf edcB | AceA ceAc | effe dcBc| AdfA dfAd | fggf efge| …

[Reel] [A] Siobhan O’Donnell’s

Joun brady



The second and third bar of the second part have a cuckoo note structure which can be replaced by a syncopated part:
| ABce fece | fAAf AAeA | fAAf AAef | aefa e2ce | …

[Hornpipe] [D] Harvest Home

Traditional



The triplets at the end of the first and third lines are non-optional.

[Jig] [D] The First Pint

Colin Farrell



Not to be confused with the Last Pint, which is a mellow, gentle-sounding air. Quite different from this bouncing, boisterous jig.

[Polka] [Am] Ballydesmond Polka #1

Traditional



The two Ballydesmond Polkas lend themselves very well to being played fast and loud. Be careful not to overdo the accompaniment, since on a guitar it can be difficult to play faster without playing louder.

[Polka] [Am] Ballydesmond Polka #2

Traditional



[Jig] [D] Haste to the Wedding

Traditional



This is one of the few really old tunes still being played today. The first written version of this tune dates to the 1700's.

[Jig] [Bm] The Banks of Lough Gowna

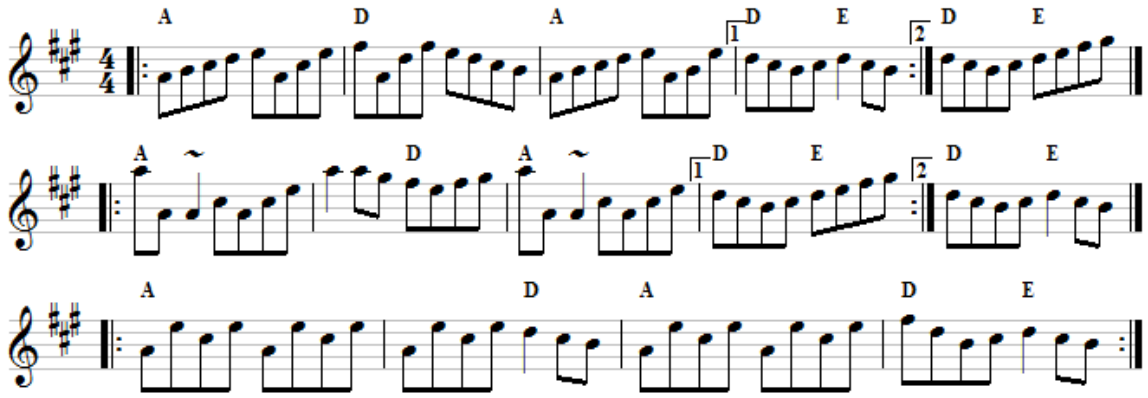
Traditional



I find this jig very similar to the Connaughtman's Rambles, but with the parts switched around.

[Reel] [A] The Boys of Malin

Traditional



Although you could view it as just a broken chord, I feel the | Aece | phrase in the third part is more like a cuckoo note structure. As such, try to accent the A and C while keep the E as a drone.

[Reel] [E] MacArthur Road

Dave Richardson



The same Dave Richardson who also wrote Calliope House. Although that one is commonly played in D, this one has remained in its original key of E. For something with so many sharps it's surprisingly easy to play, especially on violin – though the high C sharp requires second or third position playing, which is tricky to master.

[Jig] [G] Christy Barry’s #1

Christy Barry



Indeed written by mister Christy Barry himself.

[Jig] [G] The Butlers of Glen Avenue (Christy Barry’s #2)

Tony Sullivan



Flute player Kevin Crawford recorded a set of these two jigs on one of his early albums but neglected to mention the name of the second tune. Since then, it’s usually (and wrongly) referred to as Christy Barry’s #2. Let’s hope this little booklet will prevent further propagation of this misconception.

[Slip jig] [F#m] The Cock and the Hen

Traditional



F sharp minor? Come again? Fear not, the G sharp is in the key signature but is never actually played, meaning this can be played on any instrument that can do a D scale. It's a surprisingly easy tune and very lively too.

[Reel] [Am] Brenda Stubbert's

Jerry Holland



As with Siobhan O'Donnell's, the name of this tune should be interpreted as "dedicated to" rather than "written by".

A cool but difficult variation is to play the double A drones in the second part as triplets.

[Reel] [Am] The Glasgow Reel (Tam Lin)

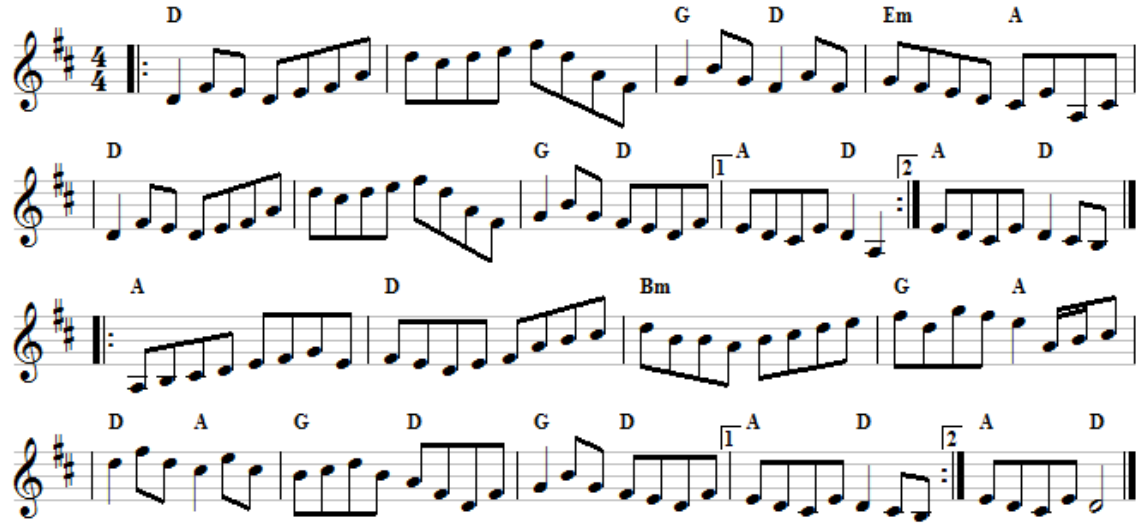
Davey Arthur



This tune is also frequently played in the key of D minor. For accompaniment it's usually nice to keep the first part more quiet, since it's in the low register of the melody instruments and therefore easy to drown. The second part has more power and can take more heavy guitaring.

[Reel] [D] The Silver Spire

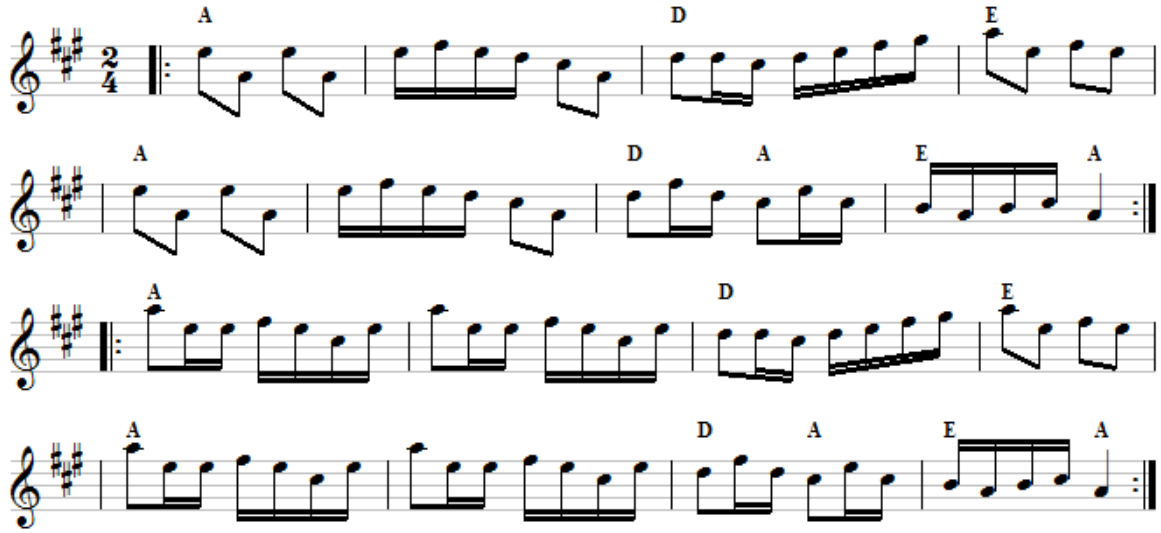
Traditional



Not to be confused with the Silver Spear. This tune sadly cannot be played on whistle or flute, because it goes down below the low D in a way that cannot be avoided without ruining the sound.

[Polka] [A] Ger the Rigger

Traditional



A lovely sounding but challenging polka, since the second part calls for some very fast fingering. Kevin Burke made a great recording of this polka (and the next one up too) on his solo fiddle album “If the Cap Fits”.

[Polka] [A] Bill Sullivan’s

Terry Teahan



This tune is commonly played near the end of a session, to finish off a set of polkas.

The key word is: fast.

[Reel] [Bm] Superfly

Kevin O'Neill



A tune with an odd name. Play it fast and loud and with a good drive. The second part is syncopated and can be accompanied in different ways. Also sounds nice with the more classical Bm – Em – F#maj chord progression.

[Reel] [A] Itchy Fingers

Robert Pinkman



One of my personal favourites, a Scottish pipe tune. When played fast and smooth, the high A drone in the second part almost vanishes and the cuckoo notes come out clearly, creating a funny little staccato phrase.

List of tunes

A Fig for a Kiss 34
Atholl Highlanders 26
The Ballintore Fancy 16
Ballydesmond Polka #1 63
Ballydesmond Polka #2 63
The Banks of Lough Gowna 64
The Banshee 45
Bill Sullivan's 69
The Blacksmith 10
The Blarney Pilgrim 30
The Boys of Blue Hill 15
The Boys of Malin 65
Brenda Stubbert's 67
Britches Full of Stitches 9
The Bucks of Oranmore 39
The Butlers of Glen Avenue (Christy Barry's #2) 66
The Butterfly 13
Calliope House 32
Christy Barry's #1 66
The Cliffs of Moher 19
The Cock and the Hen 67
Condon's Frolics 30
The Congress Reel 31
The Connaughman's Rambles 32
Cooley's 27
The Cup of Tea 54
Denis Murphy's 38
Donnybrook Fair 47
Drowsy Maggie 12
The Drunken Landlady 42
The Dusty Windowsills 43
Egan's Polka 8
The Fairy Dance 23
Father O'Flynn 57
The First Pint 62
The Fisher's 49
Ger the Rigger 69
The Glasgow Reel (Tam Lin) 68
The Glass of Beer 41
The Gravelwalks 46
The Hag at the Churn 44
Harvest Home 62
Haste to the Wedding 64
The Humours of Glendart 12
I Buried My Wife (And Danced on her Grave) 50
Inisheer 17
The Irish Washerwoman 50
Itchy Fingers 70
The Jig of Slurs 25
Jig Runrig 47
Jim Ward's 44
John Ryan's 38
Johnny Mickey's 37
The Kerfunken 8
The Kesh 9
The Kid on the Mountain 20
The King of the Faeries 28
The Lark in the Morning 35
The Leitrim Fancy 40
The Lilting Banshee 15
MacArthur Road 65
MacLeod's Farewell (The Wedding Reel) 18
Maggie in the Woods 29
The Maid Behind the Bar 27
The Maids of Ardagh 29
The Merry Blacksmith 14
Miss McLeod's 46
Morrison's 58
The Mountain Road 16
The Musical Priest 60
My Darling Asleep 19
Na Ceannabhain Bhana 33
The New Copperplate 48
O'Keefe's 21
Off to California 11
The Old Copperplate 48
Out on the Ocean 13
Paddy's Trip to Scotland 61
Padraig O'Keefe's 37
The Pigeon on the Gate 51
The Pinch of Snuff 55
The Pride of Petravore 22
The Rakish Paddy 51
Revenge of the Harmonica 33
The Rights of Man 42
Rip the Calico 41
The Road to Lisdoonvarna 21
Saddle the Pony 14
The Sailor's Hornpipe 20
The Sally Gardens 31
The Sheep on the Boat 49
Si Beag Si Mor 34
The Silver Spear 10
The Silver Spire 68
Siobhan O'Donnell's 61
The South Wind 52
The Sporting Paddy 11
St. Anne's 59
The Star of Munster 36
Superfly 70
The Swallowtail 43
Sweeney's Polka 45
The Teetotaller 36
The Trip to Durrow 53
Tripping Upstairs 40
Wild Asparagus 60
The Wind that Shakes the Barley 22